



BAAL 2026 at Aston University

Applied Linguistics in Transformation

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Aston University, Birmingham, UK

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Beyond Monologues: Lexical Bundle Length as a Predictor of L2 Fluency in Academic Multilogues

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Please tick this box if the **first author** is a PhD student (PGR).

Topics: Language acquisition, Language assessment, Language learning

Keywords: Academic Multilogues, L2 Oral Fluency, Language Assessment, Lexical Bundles, Multi-word Sequences

Language(s): English

PGR/ECR Conference Scholarship

Abstract

Multi-word sequences (MWSs) are processed more efficiently than non-formulaic language and are argued to support more fluent L2 oral production (Conklin & Schmitt, 2012), yet research has overwhelmingly focused on monologic tasks (Hougham et al., 2024). This is a notable gap given that lexical bundles (LBs) are central to academic spoken interaction, where speakers coordinate turns and negotiate meaning in real time (Mauranen, 2012). However, the relationship between bundle length and fluency in multilogues (interactions involving three or more speakers) remains unexplored. The present study examines how LB length and frequency predict fluency in multilogues across proficiency levels among L1 Japanese learners of English.

Speech data were elicited from 120 L1 Japanese (L2 English) participants grouped by CEFR level (A2–C1; $n = 30$ per level) based on an a priori power analysis (G^* Power; $r^2 = .15$, $\alpha = .05$, power = .80). Participants completed academic multilogue tasks; all interactions were annotated and acoustically measured using PRAAT, with high inter-rater agreement for pause-type labels (Cohen's $\kappa > .85$). Following Hougham et al. (2024), LBs were measured using both text-internal and text-external approaches: TAALES 2.0 identified shorter LBs against a spoken reference corpus (COCA), while AntConc was used to identify four-word bundles. Longer bundles were then manually extracted using an LB refinement procedure that accounts for overlapping sequences.

Data collection is complete and analyses are in progress. Drawing on evidence that longer MWSs reduce planning load (Kormos, 2006), we hypothesise positive LB–fluency relationships, strongest at intermediate levels where LB–proficiency associations are most pronounced (Hougham et al., 2024), diminishing at higher proficiency as speakers diversify their linguistic resources (Tavakoli & Uchihara, 2020). By integrating automated corpus tools with psycholinguistic metrics, this study advances our understanding of fluency in interactive academic speech, contributing to ongoing transformations in how applied linguistics approaches spoken data.

List of References

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Kormos, J. (2006). *Speech production and second language acquisition*. Lawrence Erlbaum.

Mauranen, A. (2012). *Exploring ELF: Academic English shaped by non-native speakers*. Cambridge University Press.

Tavakoli, P., & Uchihara, T. (2020). To what extent are multiword sequences associated with oral fluency? *Language Learning*, 70(2), 506–547. <https://doi.org/10.1111/lang.12384>

Remarks / Messages

Remark/Message from the Authors:

Dear BAAL 2026 Organising Committee,

Thank you for considering our submission. The study is currently at the analysis stage — data collection (120 participants) is complete, and the poster format is well-suited to sharing preliminary findings and inviting community feedback. The first author, Christopher Hollis, is a PhD student and would welcome consideration for the PGR/ECR Scholarship if the submission is accepted.

Sincerely,

Christopher Hollis (on behalf of all co-authors)

